Zander Willoughby

Mariehamn, Åland, Finland · zander.e.willoughby@gmail.com · +46 70 025 32 24 · linkedin.com/in/zanderewilloughby

Peace & conflict researcher and practitioner with eight years' experience across research, programme strategy, & coalition-building. Since completing a master's at Uppsala University in 2025, I have researched Åland's demilitarisation, autonomy, & minority protection at the Åland Islands Peace Institute, working in Swedish. Previously at Search for Common Ground, I co-led a global knowledge-sharing platform for 430 000+ users working in conflict-affected contexts and contributed to Search's global & country-level strategies; at the Alliance for Peacebuilding, I managed a coalition of 20+ organisations. Quantitative & spatial analysis in R; proposal writing; facilitation & mediation.

Experience

2025–present **Åland Islands Peace Institute** Mariehamn, Åland

Research Assistant July 2026–present

Erasmus+ Research Trainee Aug 2025–June 2026

- Research on the demilitarised & neutralised status of Åland, including a literature review in preparation
- Research databases & learning materials on autonomy, minority protection, and peace & security
- Support for international study visits & Track II dialogues on the Åland example
- Project & funding plan for an AI-assisted research library for the institute's archive
- Funding applications; support for the Research Council & research conferences

2024 **Nonviolent Peaceforce** Banda Aceh, Indonesia

Unarmed Civilian Protection Fellow Summer 2024 · Rotary Peace Fellowship Applied Field Experience

- Supported programme design & business development for Indonesia & Myanmar
- Co-drafted a successful 800 000 USD funding proposal for UCP programming
- Worked alongside and learned from local & regional unarmed civilian protection practitioners

2021–2025 **Search for Common Ground** Washington, DC & Uppsala (remote)

Programs & Networks Officer 2024–2025

Communications Officer & Co-Lead, ConnexUs 2022–2024

Youth, Peace & Security Advocacy Expert 2021–2022

- Co-led ConnexUs, a knowledge-sharing platform for 430 000+ peacebuilders, and its supporting projects funded by USAID, the State Department, & Sida
- Contributed to Search's global & country-level strategies and the Peace Impact Framework rollout; designed & delivered global trainings
- Produced & hosted 30+ international webinars; 30% open rates across 10 000+ newsletter subscribers
- Advocated for, & contributed to drafting, the US Youth, Peace & Security Act and Global Peacebuilding Act

2019–2021 **+Peace, Alliance for Peacebuilding** Washington, DC

Program Manager 2020–2021

Network & Communications Coordinator 2019–2020

- Led the coalition as sole staff member after the director's departure in 2020: budget, operations, & hiring, through a leadership transition & strategic re-visioning
- Coordinated 20+ member organisations, including Search for Common Ground, Peace Direct, International Alert, and Conciliation Resources; co-designed the coalition's governance review with members
- Policy advocacy on the Global Fragility Act and the Elie Wiesel Genocide and Atrocities Prevention Act
- Co-facilitated the Peace in Our Cities network, connecting violence-prevention experts with municipal leaders; campaigns, social media, & website

2018–2019 **Manchester University Peace Studies Institute** Indiana, USA

Peace Studies Coordinator

- Academic programming, events, & off-campus experiential learning; supervised four student workers

2016–2017 **European Parliament** Strasbourg, France

Intern, Committee on Development

- Background research on EU migration & development policy

Education

2023–2025 **Uppsala University** Uppsala, Sweden
Master of Social Science, Peace and Conflict Studies 120 ECTS
- Department of Peace and Conflict Research; Rotary Peace Fellow
- Thesis: *Boiling Points: Gender Inequality as a Moderator for Climate Change & Communal Violence*, pass with distinction
- Pass with distinction in 9 of 11 courses

2014–2018 **Manchester University** Indiana, USA
BA Political Science & French, *cum laude*
- Minor in Peace Studies

2016–2017 **Sciences Po Strasbourg & Institut International d'études françaises** Strasbourg, France
- Exchange year: international relations, political science & French, high honours

Publications

2025 'Saving Strangers or Keeping Ourselves Safe? An Analysis of Peacekeeping & Unarmed Civilian Protection', *Pax et Bellum Journal* 12. doi:10.33063/pbj.v12i2025.702

Languages

English Native | Swedish C1 | French B2
German Basic | Spanish Basic

Skills

Research	Quantitative & spatial analysis in R; mixed-methods research design; qualitative coding & codebook development; data cleaning & reproducible workflows
Strategy & programmes	Strategy development; Theory of Change; monitoring, evaluation, & learning; proposal writing & donor reporting; budget & partnership management; training design
Communications	Knowledge platform management; webinar production & facilitation; email & digital communications; WordPress; Canva

Selected training

Peacebuilding	Common Ground Approach, advanced; Peace Impact Framework (Search for Common Ground, 2022–2023)
Mediation	Interpersonal mediation certification & advanced mediation (Education for Conflict Resolution, 2018–2019)
Analysis	Conflict analysis, Making Sense of Conflict (GPPAC, 2020); QGIS & geodata (Uppsala University Library, 2025)
Climate	Capacity Building Programme on climate diplomacy & COP31 preparation (Nordic Youth Climate Alliance, 2026)

Positions of trust

2026–present **Nordic Youth Climate Alliance**, governance & funding working groups; SB64 (online) & COP31 delegations
2023–2025 **Rotary District 1410** (Southern Finland), Peace Ambassador
2020–2024 **Global Coalition for Youth, Peace & Security**, knowledge-sharing & communications task forces
2020–2022 **Search for Common Ground**, Global Youth Leadership Council
2018–2019 **Education for Conflict Resolution**, mediator, mediation trainer, & board member
2014–2019 **Manchester University Peace Studies Institute**, board member (2014–2016 & 2018–2019)

References available upon request.